

WAR
ON TERROR
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BE FAST AND Precise

India's armed forces must modernise and move to hi-tech precision strikes to take on non-state adversaries as well as traditional rivals

In 2001, in the wake of the terrorist attack on Parliament, the Government ordered the Indian armed forces to mobilise. But by the time the forces were ready—on January 11—not only was the Pakistan Army mobilised, but Islamabad was ready to give guarantees that it would end all terrorist activity emanating from Pakistani soil. The moment passed.

The November 26 attack has brought on a sense of déjà vu. Despite claims that the army had, since 2002, adopted a new "Cold Start" doctrine, there are no signs of any Army movement other than routine training.

India enjoys a qualitative and quantitative edge over Pakistan in its air and naval assets, but their armies are evenly matched. On paper, India's army is almost twice the size of

Pakistan's, but a fourth of it is involved in counter-insurgency operations and a significant part on the Sino-Indian border.

This does not even begin to factor in the emergence of the new model People's Liberation Army as a high-tech, highly mobile force. The Chinese are creating a world class army that can take on any counterpart, including the US. The Chinese did have a major logistical problem in Tibet till recently. But now, their newly built road and rail network has transformed the situation.

The problems of the Indian armed forces are in all three areas—organisation, equipment and doctrine, and, the joker in the pack—political direction.

In the early 1980s, the political directive to the three services was that they were to maintain "dissuasive deterrence" vis-à-vis Pakistan and "defensive deter-

rence" in relation to China. This meant that they had to have the capability of undertaking a deep offensive into Pakistan, but with regard to China the policy was to have the kind of defensive strength that would dissuade Beijing from a military strike. Factor in nuclear capability and the doctrine itself changes as was clear in the Kargil war when India insisted in limiting it to the incursion area. There have been several efforts to amend it—the "limited war" idea during General V.P. Malik's time and the "cold start" doctrine during General S. Padmanabhan's tenure.

Whenever political direction has been clear—1947, 1971, 1999—the armed forces have performed well. Whenever it has been confused or absent, there is frustration and disaster—1965 and 1962. The armed forces are